At first Bhidranwale expressed his usual grievances with the 'Hindu' government's discriminatory attitude towards Sikhs. Swaran Singh advised him that he had better not get involved in such demands as these were a part of Akali demands also. Singh was finally able to bring down Bhindranwale to one small demand, which was the unconditional release of Amrik Singh and Thara Singh. Bhindranwale also agreed to move back to his Mehta Chowk gurudwara once a final settlement was reached and his men were released.

Swaran Singh had been keeping Indira Gandhi informed about the outcome of his meetings at regular intervals, including the one with Bhindranwale. He also 'conveyed to her the details of the agreement on Anandpur Sahib Resolution and the distribution of waters, the two principal demands. She accepted the settlement and praised him for his painstaking efforts. She, however, told him that she would like the matter to be placed before a cabinet sub-committee, which she constituted immediately, with Pranab Mukherjee, R. Venkataraman, P.V. Narsimha Rao, and P.C. Sethi as its members.' [14] Indira Gandhi also agreed that senior Akali leaders be called to Delhi for formal discussions with the sub-committee.

'Ghosts Behind Every Bush'

At this stage I would like to mention that I came to know about the negotiations with the Akalis sometime in early October 1982. Since I had already come to know, through my friend from Patiala, about the Congress conspiring to win the next general elections through a dramatic solution to a deliberately manufactured crisis in Punjab, I told my father-in-law that if my information was correct he would not be able to work out a compromise formula, and it would be sabotaged on one pretext or the other. He said, 'You intelligence people are in the habit of seeing ghosts behind every bush.' I wished him success. In my mind, I decided that the success or failure of my father-in-law's efforts to broker a compromise would be a litmus test for the veracity or otherwise of the information my friend had conveyed to me.